

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 152

By Jones J

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor the fifteen enslaved persons who helped build the Tennessee State Capitol.

WHEREAS, it is most fitting, especially as we commemorate Black History Month, to honor the lives and indelible contributions of those Tennesseans whose names might otherwise be lost to time; and

WHEREAS, between the spring of 1846 and January 1847, fifteen enslaved Nashvillians were rented by the State government to complete an early phase of construction of the State Capitol; twelve names of these fifteen individuals have been ascertained through historical record: Lewis, Daniel, Robert, Nelson, John, Parker, Dang, Bill, John G., John, Andrew, and Jim; and

WHEREAS, the site of the Capitol was a large limestone formation covered with a thin layer of soil; these fifteen men came to the construction project after the soil was removed and the heavy limestone beneath remained, using picks and crowbars to break the rock and carrying it away on flatbed wheel barrows; and

WHEREAS, these men were undoubtedly skilled laborers, as indicated by the task itself, that of carving the Capitol's cellar to exact specifications, and by the price that A.G. Payne was paid for their work: \$18.00 per month, per enslaved person, which was more than double the typical rate and nearly double the rate for unskilled free labor; and

WHEREAS, for fourteen years, until the death of A.G. Payne, these fifteen men worked at both a farm and brick factory, the monotony briefly punctuated by being hired out; they remained with his widow until their emancipation in 1865; and

WHEREAS, the men did not have the option of becoming sharecroppers on the land that Payne owned, as it was sold off to satisfy debts of the estate, but they may have been able to put their training and skills to use; and

WHEREAS, in the end, however, the former enslaved persons who had helped construct the Capitol found themselves in the same position as four million other newly emancipated individuals—empowered by their freedom but ultimately limited in employment due to what the South would soon become in terms of race relations; and

WHEREAS, the enslaved men who participated in the construction of the Capitol made a significant contribution to their State and country that Tennesseans appreciate to this day; knowing the story of these individuals adds to both the history of the Capitol and the broad topic of slavery's impact in Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, by accepting the unfortunate irony that slavery was used to construct a building meant for the purpose of democracy, we can truly appreciate how far that democracy has come in the time since these enslaved persons left their mark on history; as the beneficiaries of their work, we must afford them the correct and appropriate recognition they earned over a century and a half ago; and

WHEREAS, for too long, these fifteen individuals have not been given proper recognition, and it is our privilege and duty to rectify this dereliction and duly credit the skilled men who helped create one of our State's most treasured landmarks; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor the memories and legacies of the fifteen enslaved persons, including Lewis, Daniel, Robert, Nelson, John, Parker, Dang, Bill, John G., John, Andrew, and Jim, whose skilled labor helped build the Tennessee State Capitol.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.